

ELEVATOR PITCH

Working title: Nearby (placeholder - needs a final name)

THE PITCH

Nearby is a passive, notification-driven nature discovery app. Instead of hunting for wildlife or photographing it to catch it, you get a push notification when a real species (animal, bird, insect, plant) is plausibly present in your area right now, based on real range, habitat, and seasonal data. Tap the notification, learn a few real facts about the species, and it is added to your personal collection. Over time, you build a living almanac of everything that shares your surroundings, whether you ever physically see it or not.

THE PROBLEM

Existing nature-ID apps (Seek, iNaturalist, Merlin Bird ID) all require active effort: you must go outside, spot something, and photograph or describe it before you learn anything. That is great for dedicated naturalists and citizen scientists, but it is a barrier for casual curiosity. Most people who would enjoy learning what lives around them never open these apps, because the apps demand a hunt first.

Meanwhile, Pokemon GO-style AR games proved that location-based collection mechanics are extremely engaging, but every major clone reskins the loop around fictional creatures. Nobody has applied the low-friction, ambient version of that loop to real, local biodiversity.

THE SOLUTION

- Push notification when a real species is plausibly present nearby, based on range and seasonality data such as GBIF or eBird public APIs.
- Tap to learn a short fact card covering habitat, behavior, and rarity.
- Auto-collect into a personal library, with no photo and no proof required.
- Rarity and completion mechanics: common versus rare local species, seasonal specials, collection badges by category.
- Optional confirm-sighting layer for users who want to log a real photographed encounter later.

WHY THIS GAP EXISTS

Every existing app in this space is built by or with naturalist and conservation institutions whose mission requires verified data. A no-proof collect mechanic has no scientific value, so it does not fit their purpose. That is the opportunity: a product built purely for engagement and ambient learning can be simpler and more habit-forming than anything currently on the market.

TARGET USER

- Casual nature-curious people who would not open a serious naturalist app
- Parents wanting a low-effort educational habit for kids
- Commuters and urban dwellers who want a reason to notice their surroundings
- Anyone who enjoyed Pokemon GO's core loop but wants it grounded in reality

DIFFERENTIATION AT A GLANCE

Seek and iNaturalist require a photo, use real species, are not passive, and have high scientific data value.

Pokemon GO-style AR games require no photo but use fictional creatures, are not passive, and have no scientific data value.

Nearby requires no photo, uses real species, is passive and ambient by design, and does not aim for scientific data value.

RISKS TO VALIDATE NEXT

- Does collecting without ever confirming presence feel rewarding or hollow? Needs early playtesting.
- Data source reliability: range data is real but not hyper-local or real-time, so notification cadence and geographic granularity need careful tuning.
- Retention mechanics: without a go-outside-and-find-it hook, what keeps people opening the app day to day?

NEXT STEP

Scope a lean MVP covering species range API integration, notification design, and the collection library UI, targeting a narrow initial region such as Sweden or Kronoberg to validate before expanding.